

fridayReview

THE HINDU

Music as a way of life

Tribute to Prof. S.R. Janakiraman, who passed way recently **p2**

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BACK TO HINDI CINEMA'S GOLDEN ERA

Meena Kumari's final film, *Pakeezah*, has been restored and will be screened in France **p4**

At CultureCon 2026 held in Mumbai, musicians and cultural leaders debated what technology can replicate and what remains distinctly human

Arundhuti Banerjee

Conversations drifted through the space, mingling with the aroma of coffee and the hum of people moving between sessions. Attendees listened, debated and exchanged ideas in the auditorium, while discussions spilled into the cafeteria and corridors outside.

This was CultureCon 2026 at the National Centre for the Performing Arts (NCPA), where the networking mixer brought together artistes and cultural practitioners from across disciplines. Patchy network connectivity provided an unexpected respite from phones, directing attention to the conversations unfolding on stage.

And the conversation there centred around a question that is becoming increasingly difficult for the creative world to ignore: when AI can generate images, music, text and video with increasing ease, what happens to originality, artistic labour and the human impulse to create?

For Sanjoy Roy of Teamwork Arts, this democratisation is not entirely new. In his view, technology has long lowered the barriers to creative participation. "The minute these phones came about, everything got democratised because you were taking photographs. This has made everybody a filmmaker. This has made everybody a creative artiste. This has made everybody a meme. This has made everybody an influencer."

But if technology can draw from everything that already exists, what happens to the artiste whose value lies in imagining something that does not? Roshan Abbas, a storyteller, media entrepreneur and creative industry leader, sees that distinction in originality. "I keep saying that art is created in the extraordinary, art is created in the flaw, art is created in the anomaly. So, AI, unfortunately, is aggregating what is already available. Art is about that which has never been seen," he says.

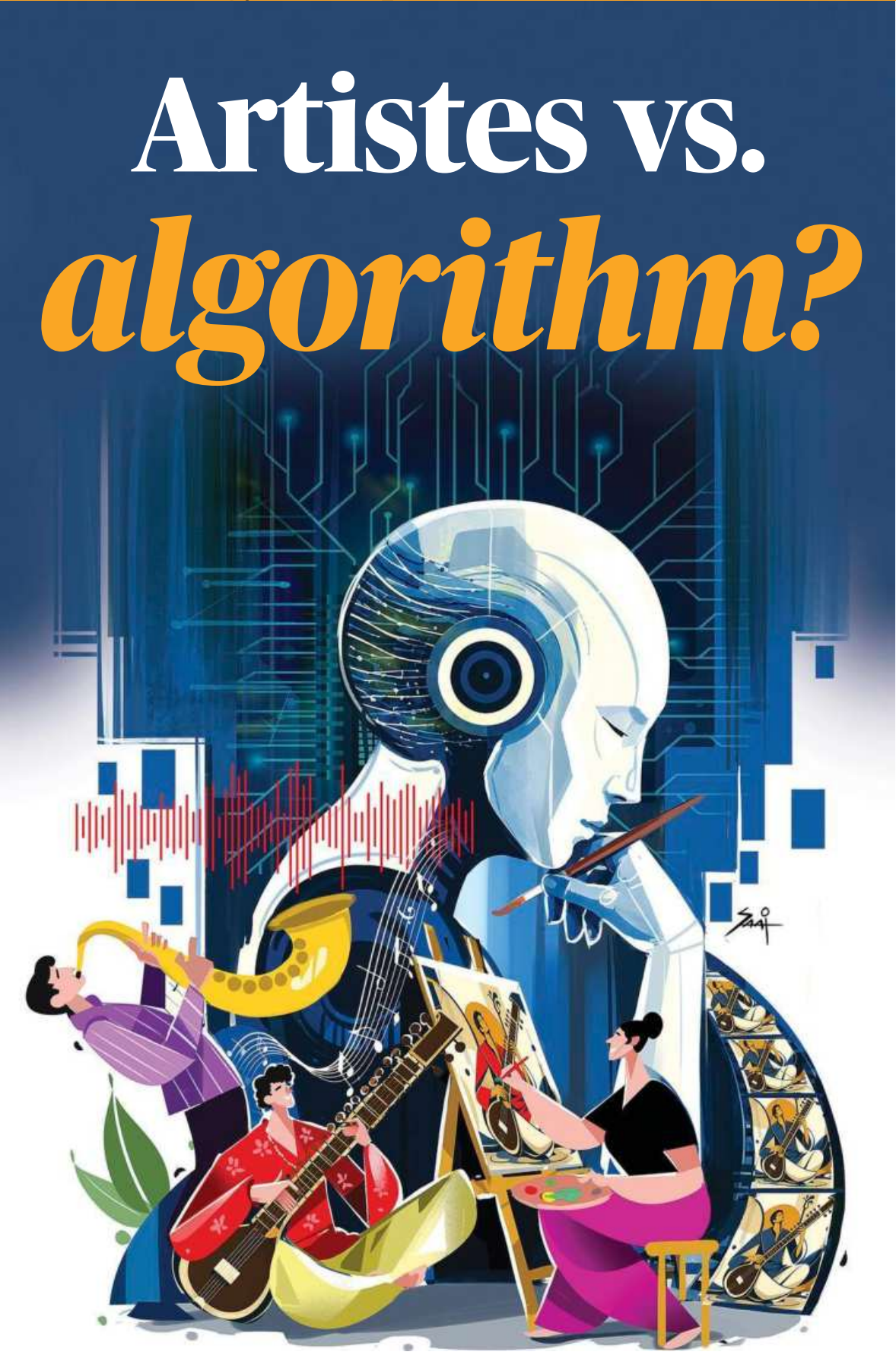
For Abbas, the imaginative leap remains uniquely human. He explains, "If you had aggregated a tape recorder and a phone, you would not have got an iPhone. So, it requires somebody who's a bit of a creative thinker. And I think that's what is important to celebrate, really, people who can think out of the box."

Musician and producer Karsh Kale sees a similar limitation in AI: its inability to anticipate an artiste's next move. Kale says, "But the one thing AI can't do is predict what the next thing an artiste is going to do. It can study a particular artiste – Mozart, Bach, Ustad Zakir Hussain or Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan – and recreate everything that they have done. What it can't do is predict what the next thing they were going to do, and that's where that human element is still important."

The human element becomes sharper when creativity is viewed not just as an idea, but as labour. Musician Jishnu Dasgupta, bassist and manager of folk-rock band Swarathma, takes a more uncompromising position. Jishnu says, "I have a sharp stance on AI in the creative field. I believe it has no place in creativity at all. Creative expression is inherently a human condition. It makes the unbearable weight of human existence more bearable. That is the point of art – it is something that is as critical to life as breathing or as eating."

For Jishnu, efficiency can come at the cost of meaning. He says, "As we infuse more of the so-called artificial intelligence to take the humanness out of art, we are doing a disservice to it even though it appears that we are doing things more efficiently. So, even though we can probably make a large number of songs quickly with AI, you are stripping them of the very soul that creative expression is all about."

Jishnu also questions AI's role in making live events more sustainable. He says, "I do not think AI is helping make live events and concert tours more sustainable in any way." On creative decisions, he believes the boundary must be drawn. He says, "AI should not



become integral to planning and producing events. It cannot replace human judgment in doing something that has never been done before."

Yet the debate at CultureCon was not about rejecting technology in favour of artistic purity. Sanjoy Roy cautions against defining creativity through tradition alone. He says, "This is not about the pure Carnatic tradition or Hindustani music. Learning from tradition does not mean reproducing it mechanically. "By producing exactly what your guruji has taught is not creativity. It is when you make it your own, interpret it and then create a new form within the meter. And, that is creativity."

For Karsh Kale, the question extends beyond originality to the physical labour involved in mastering an art form. He believes that such labour could become more valuable in an age of abundant machine-made output. "I think we're eventually going to come to a point where that's valued more, because there's going to be so much output of different types. So actually even seeing somebody weave a chair is going to be fascinating, because the human element is what's going to be worth more than anything else."

That value, however, lies not only in creating art but also in communicating it. Roshan Abbas believes storytelling will become increasingly important in the AI era, particularly for artistes who struggle to articulate their work. "I find many people who are great practitioners of their art, but are not able to actually put things out. Many people I find are diffident; they don't know how to tell their story. So that's where I feel it is important to actually enhance your skills of storytelling."

If technology can increasingly produce the form, perhaps what becomes more valuable is not simply the finished work, but the human impulse, labour, imagination and experience behind it.

V.V. Ramani

The year was 1994, and the arts fraternity was abuzz with excitement over a dance production that toured the U.S. and Canada, staging 23 full-house shows. The talking point was its music score, composed by violin maestro Lalgudi Jayaraman, and the choreography by Rhadha, a scion of the Vazhuvoor bani. Titled 'Jaya Jaya Devi', the production was commissioned by V.V. Sundaram and premiered at the Cleveland Tyagaraja Aradhana in 1994.

Recalling how their father, Lalgudi Jayaraman, composed the music for this iconic production in just six months, Lalgudi Krishnan and Vijayalakshmi say: "Though he had composed many thillanas that have become a part of the Bharatanatyam repertoire, this was the first time he was composing for an isai natya nadakam. He not only composed the music but also wrote the lyrics. The theme, research and script were by scholar Sujatha Vijayaraghavan, who would have regular discussions with *appa* over the narrative and storytelling."



Return of a classic

'Jaya Jaya Devi', featuring Lalgudi Jayaraman's music score and Rhadha's choreography, will be staged after three decades

Iconic collaboration Lalgudi Jayaraman and Rhadha. PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES

Krishnan and Vijayalakshmi have now revived 'Jaya Jaya Devi' with the aim of introducing this pioneering work to a younger generation of dancers and audiences. Presented by the Lalgudi Trust, it will be staged at Narada Gana Sabha on September 19 (6 p.m.).

"It was a labour of love for everyone involved. There were no ego clashes, the camaraderie between my father and guru Rhadha was such that she could suggest changes to the music to suit her choreography and *appa* would readily accommodate them. He would also frequently attend rehearsals to see how his music was visualised. The wholehearted involvement of the orchestra and dancers further enriched the creative process," says Krishnan.

Vocalist S.P. Ramh, a disciple of Lalgudi Jayaraman, was not only the lead male voice but also the one who notated the compositions. "It was a gurukulavasam for me, where

I learnt the nuances of music-making. I witnessed how the two artistes continuously refined their work at every stage. It was an amazing experience to sing live for all the 23 performances alongside Sumitra Nitin," he recalls.

The production stood out for its many innovative elements. Reflecting on them, Vijayalakshmi says, "For instance, in the sequence on Spring and Manmadha, *appa* used tanam in raga Vasantha to evoke the mood. A lot of thought went into each segment. For the episode on Durga, Sindhubhairavi was the main raga, but to portray the goddess's many facets, ragas such as Mohanakalyani, Chenchurutti and Behag were woven through grahabhedam. The entire segment was set to swara passages. His



contrasting use of musical phrases to depict tandava and lasya in the Nalinakanthi thillana was widely applauded."

Hyma Ramakrishna, who designed the costumes in the original, recreates them for the upcoming performance as well. A new set of young dancers – Divya Nayar, Sumithra Subramaniam, Nideesh Kumar, Varsha Rajkumar, Sundaresan Pandurangan, Satvika Shankar, Smrithika, Shruthipriya Vignesh and Tanish Karthik are playing the roles performed earlier by artistes who are now established names in the field. Raksha Raghavan and Shruthi Vidyashankar are the narrators. Linking the two presentations is P.C. Ramakrishna, who returns in the role of Nandideva.

Unlike the original, which had a live orchestra, the revival will be performed to recorded music, put together at Resound India, featuring vocalists R.P. Shravan, Sunil Gargyan, Krithika Arvind and Janani Hamsini. Nattuvangam is by Jayashree Ramanathan. The music team

comprises Lalgudi Vijayalakshmi on the violin, Sai Shrivaram on the tabla, Sruti Sagar on the flute, Karthikeyan Ramanathan on the mridangam, Ganapathy on the chendai and urmi and Rajagopal on the morsing and udakkai.

Rhadha, who has retained the original choreography, has trained the dancers for the revived version too. Speaking about the differences between then and now, she says, the biggest challenge today is the paucity of time, with most dancers juggling multiple commitments. Yet, their involvement and enthusiasm are commendable."

'Jaya Jaya Devi' holds a special place in Rhadha's heart, as it brought her recognition. "Choreographing for the maestro's musical score remains the high point of my artistic journey."

For those who watched it three decades ago, the revival promises a trip down memory lane, but for first-time viewers, it offers a refreshing experience.

The event is open to all. For details visit the link: <https://kynhood.com/event/6a6dc85d5b63cc1001732b62>.



▶ **Ode to a scholar** (Clockwise from left) Prof. S.R. Janakiraman; with Prof. T.R. Subramaniam and during a lecture demonstration on Ekaika raga kritis of Muthuswami Dikshitar in 2009. PHOTOS: K.V. SRINIVASAN; SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND R. RAVINDRAN



Vidwan in the truest sense

S.R. Janakiraman, who passed away recently, was a guiding light for generations of musicians and an authoritative voice on the theory and practice of Carnatic music

H. Ramakrishnan

Sangita Kala Acharya S.R. Janakiraman, who passed away last week at the age of 98, was a renowned musicologist, scholar and a mentor, who shaped the Carnatic music landscape for over half a century, deepening the understanding of the classical art. He lived true to his belief that a musicologist must also be a musician. He trained under doyens such as ‘Tiger’ Varadachari, Budalur Krishnamurthy Sastri, Musiri Subramania Iyer, T. Brinda and Tiruppambaram Swaminatha Pillai and was initiated into musicology by Professor P. Sambamurthi and Balakrishna Ayya. His lecture demonstrations were not only instructive, but inspiring as well. Janakiraman was the Head of the Department of Musicology at Sri Venkateswara College of

Music, Tirupati. He was fluent in Telugu too and authored *Sangita Sastra Saramu* – a two-volume book. During his tenure as a research scholar at The Music Academy, he authored three comprehensive volumes of *Raga Lakshanas* in Tamil and co-authored *Ragas of Saramrita*, a commentary of the Raga Chapter of King Tulaja’s treatise *Sangita Saramrita*. He also wrote *Ragas at a Glance*, a compendium of the individual lakshanas of popular ragas. He was a loving and generous teacher, who made no distinction of hierarchy. Musician Sriram Parasuram describes his guru as a traditionalist and purist to the core, yet the most inquiring and innovative musical mind. He had mastered musical granthas from the *Natya Sastra*, *Sangeetha Ratnakara*, *Raga Vibhodha* to the *Sangeetha Sampradaya Pradarsini*. He could quote the minutest detail from a page



Inspiring presence

In his tribute, veteran natyacharya V.P. Dhananjayan recalled his long association with S.R. Janakiraman: “He was a walking encyclopedia on Carnatic sangeetham and a musician’s guide all through his life. I had the privilege of interacting with him, apart from being his junior contemporary at Kalakshetra. His vision problems never diminished his enthusiasm for sharing his vast knowledge with seekers across the world. He continued to teach students online until his very last days. The best way to celebrate SRJ is to emulate the generosity with which he shared his vidwat with generations of learners.”

number to the paragraph despite the problem with his vision. Any query would be answered with an instant sastra-based explanation. Senior vocalist P. Unnikrishnan, who had learnt from Janakiraman, recalls his guru shedding tears whenever he remembered flautist Tiruppambaram Swaminathan Pillai. “He would often render the ragas in the style of the maestro. His ideas of ragas were unique, and he developed his own patanthara. His swaraprastara patterns had a distinctive mathematical combination, effective and comfortable to follow.”

Jayakrishnan Unni, another of the musicologist’s disciple, recalls his guru singing the songs that he learnt 60 or 70 years ago with utmost clarity. Jayakrishnan learnt several rare varnams, including those by Tiger Varadachari, from *Sangeetha Sampradaya Pradarsini*, and one in Balahamsa. “He would suddenly start singing swaras in a raga for 30 to 40 minutes at a stretch. Inspiring anecdotes and references accompanied every single composition he taught. He has tuned several Annamacharya kritis and would reverentially and emotionally remember Rallapalli Ananthakrishna Sharma, who had done extensive research on Annamacharya kritis.” As the legendary P.S. Narayanaswamy once said, when the title ‘Nada Yogi’ was awarded to SRJ, he is a ‘paripoorna vidwan blessed by god, a musician’s musician’.

Annual music competition

The Music Academy conducts the annual music competition on October 3 and 4. Details of the contest and application form are available at the Academy’s office or can be downloaded from Music Academy’s website. Last date is September 25. For more information call 044-2811 2231 or 2811 3162.

Endowment concerts

The Music Academy has organised the following concerts at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. Details: Today, 6 p.m.: Guhan R. Venkaraman (veena) with Vignesh Venkatraman (mridangam) and N. Phanindra (ghatam). The concert is organised under the endowment instituted by Shankar Annaswamy in memory of his sister, Nagalakshmi Anantharaman. September 13, 10.30 a.m.: ‘Exploring the Musical and Lyrical Profundity of Sri Krishna Leela Tarangini’ by Bhairavi Vaitheeswaran. This lecдем is organised under the endowment, instituted by Sri and Smt. S. Krishnaswami and V. Vijayagopal, in memory of Sarita Vijayagopal.



Spotlight on dance

Natyanjali Trust will celebrate dance by presenting three special events at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore, beginning today. Today at 6.45 p.m. senior Bharatanatyam dancer Alarmel Valli will be honoured with ‘The Flame of Bharatanatyam’ award. The evening’s programme also includes Bharatanatyam performance by the students of Nandhini Suresh (5.30 p.m.); screening of ‘Lasya Kavya - The World of Alarmel Valli’ (6.05 p.m.) and performances by Manaswini Ramachandran, Sumitra Subramaniam and Shahana Kasi at 7.30 p.m. The Trust’s annual festivals will be held subsequently — Natya festival on September 15 and 16; and the 19th year Nartaka festival on September 17 and 18. Natya festival begins with the Kuchipudi performance by the students of Vempati Srimayi on September 15 at 5.30 p.m., followed by the Bharatanatyam performances of Apeksha Kamatha at 6.30 p.m., and disciples of Roja Kannan (7.30 p.m.). Day two will feature the following Bharatanatyam performances: 5.30 p.m.: Disciples of Priya Murlie; 6.30 p.m.: Sudharma Vaithiyanathan; and 7.30 p.m.: Students of Parvathi Ravi Ghantasala. The Nartaka Festival begins with the Bharatanatyam performances by Rakesh K.P. and Atul Balu on September 17 at 5.30 p.m. followed by the presentation of Nartaka Award to M.V.N. Murthy (6.30 p.m.) and performances by Advith Shashidhar, Kedar Gaurav and Sarath Naik (7.30 p.m.) The festival concludes on September 18 with the performances by Shreejith Satyan and Arun Velayudhan (5.30 p.m.); Unnath, Pavan Kumar and Bhuvan Kumar (6.30 p.m.) and Parshwanath Upadhye and Adithya PV (7.30 p.m.).

Dedicated to Bharati

Nritya Samsrti Trust, in association with Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore, will present ‘Bharati: Ninaivalla Neri’, a remembrance day tribute to the Tamil poet Subramania Bharati, on September 12, 10 a.m. at Bhavan’s Mylapore venue. The programme includes the launch of the educational initiative ‘Aravor Vazhiyil’, followed by the presentation of endowment honours and a speech by Rajkumar Bharati. **Madhuradhwani** has organised the following events as part of the 105th remembrance day of Subramania Bharati. Details: Today, 5.15 p.m.: R. Suryaprakash (vocal) with Gayathri Vibhavari (violin) and Aduthurai Guruprasad (mridangam) and 6.45 p.m.: A special talk ‘Bharatiyum Chellammavum’ by senior journalist Malan.



Choodamani awards

On the occasion of the 70th Margazhi Mela to be presented by Krishna Gana Sabha in December 2026, the Choodamani awards will be given to an accomplished Carnatic musician and a dancer. Mridangist Tiruvarur Vaidyanathan will be conferred the Sangeetha Choodamani title. He will be the 65th recipient of this award. Bharatanatyam dancer and teacher Indira Kadambi will be honoured with the Nritya Choodamani title. She will be the 59th recipient of this title. The awards will be presented on the inaugural day of the Margazhi festival to be hosted by the sabha on December 12 at 5 p.m. Venue: Nalli Gana Vihar, T. Nagar.

A festive flow of melody

B. Vijayagopal’s flute recital was about lyrical raga exploration and nuanced accompaniment

Aishwarya Raghunathan

Mudhra’s five-day Venuganam festival, held from September 2 to 6 as part of the Janmashtami celebrations, returned for its third edition with a thoughtfully curated tribute to the flute. The festival’s second day featured flautist B. Vijayagopal with B. Ananthakrishnan on the violin, Vijay Natesan on the mridangam and Tiruchi Krishnaswamy on the ghatam. Vijayagopal opened with a compact sketch of Kamalamanoohari. Though brief, the alapana was sufficiently evocative to establish the raga’s contours before moving to Muthuswami Dikshitar’s ‘Kanchadalayatakshi’. The flute and the violin found a natural conversational space, with Ananthakrishnan responding sensitively to Vijayagopal’s phrases, while the mridangam and ghatam provided a firm, unobtrusive rhythmic foundation. A well-placed set of



kalpanaswaras neatly tied the piece together. This was followed by Tyagaraja’s ‘Baganayya’ in Chandrajyothi, presented with a smooth tonal flow. Behag came up next, with Vijayagopal offering a pleasing alapana marked by neat brigas and a seamless movement across the octaves. Ananthakrishnan closely mirrored the flute’s melodic contours, bringing out the raga’s character with sensitivity. Swati Tirunal’s ‘Smara janaka’, set to Misra Chapu tala was his next choice. The kriti ensued in a

neat round of kalpanaswaras, set to two kalams. The mridangam and ghatam worked in close coordination, providing lively support. A change of pace came with Patnam Subramania Iyer’s ‘Garuda gamana’ in Nagaswaravali. Played in madhyama kala, the rendition added another shade to the concert’s carefully chosen repertoire, reflecting the variety of composers and compositions that marked the evening. Staying true to the bhava-rich character of raga Abheri, an expressive alapana

paved the way for Mysore Vasudevachar’s ‘Bhajiare re manasa’. The rendition sustained its emotional depth throughout, capturing the calm devotion embedded in the composition. A niraval at ‘Ravana mardhanam’ was followed by a precise round of kalpanaswaras, with the mridangam and ghatam responding with utmost sensitivity. The ensuing tani avarthanam was built around skilful on-and-off-beat sollus, with the two percussionists complementing each other and maintaining a balance throughout.

▶ **Wide repertoire** B. Vijayagopal with B. Ananthakrishnan on the violin, Vijay Natesan on the mridangam and Tiruchi Krishnaswamy on the ghatam. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A shift in mood came with Kalki Krishnamurthi’s ‘Malai pozhudhinile’, a ragamallika featuring Chenchurutti, Behag, Sindhubhairavi, Mohanam and Mayamalavagowla. The recital ended on a buoyant note with Patnam Subramania Iyer’s Khamas thillana.

Vaishali K.S.

While many musicians devote themselves to building their own careers, some choose to invest just as deeply in nurturing the art and shaping the next generation of practitioners. Pt. Vinayak Torvi belongs to the latter category. To celebrate the renowned Hindustani vocalist and guru's 78th birthday, a music festival aptly titled *Dharohar* was organised recently in Bengaluru.

A disciple of the legendary Pt. Gururao Deshpande and Pt. Bhimsen Joshi, Pt. Torvi blossomed into a consummate vocalist and went on to inspire several youngsters to pursue Hindustani classical music. His gayaki, reflecting a rich confluence of Gwalior, Kirana, Agra and Jaipur influences, is distinguished by its powerful expression, refined layakari and soulful aistry. There is another important dimension to his musicianship: his unwavering commitment to nurturing the next generation of artistes. Over the years, he has trained several talented disciples, including Amrita Deshpande, Keerti Kumar Badseshi, Dhananjay Hegde, Dattatreya Velankar and Siddhartha Belmannu. It was inspiring to listen to Pt. Torvi recount some of the defining moments in his musical journey.

As a young vocalist, he was overwhelmed when a recital in Hubli drew thunderous applause from the audience. What took him completely by surprise, however, was the sight of his guru, Pt. Gururao Deshpande, and the legendary Gangubai Hangal listening with rapt attention from behind the stage, perhaps choosing to remain out of sight so as not to intimidate him. Recalling the occasion, Pt. Torvi said that when Gangubai ji remarked that he was a promising vocalist, her words of appreciation gave his morale an immense boost and strengthened his resolve to pursue music with greater conviction.

Speaking about his transfer to the Bengaluru branch of Canara Bank as a young employee, Pt. Torvi described himself as a reluctant



High note (Clockwise from left) Pt. Vinayak Torvi; with guru Pt. Bhimsen Joshi; and grandson Rishabh Badsesh at his debut concert. PHOTOS: G.P SAMPATH KUMAR & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Hindustani music's southern home

'Dharohar' honoured Pt. Vinayak Torvi for giving the art form a lasting foothold in Bengaluru's cultural landscape

musician who felt dejected at the prospect of settling in a city where Carnatic music was more popular. "I pleaded with the then chairman Mr. Eknath Kamath, a great admirer of Pt. Kumar Gandharva, to send me to Pune," Pt. Torvi recalled. "But Mr. Kamath said, 'Mr. Torvi, Bengaluru is one of the fastest-growing cities. Don't you think you can sow the seeds of Hindustani classical music there and build a community of musicians?' His encouraging words turned out to be prophetic." Torvi said. Another transcendental moment in his journey was when Pt. Torvi became the first artiste to get rapturous encore requests from the audience at the historic Sawai Gandharv festival in Pune, a dream

destination for every accomplished Hindustani classical musician. Equally unforgettable was the appreciation he received from Pt Bhimsen Joshi. The veteran considers himself fortunate to have had exemplary disciples who pursued music with fervour and remained under his tutelage for over three decades. "In Carnatic music all-night mehfls are unheard of. I wanted to introduce this concept in Bengaluru, but many people were doubtful about the viability of such a music festival. Even the inimitable Pt. Dinkar Kaikini advised me to hold either a morning or an evening session instead. However, I was determined and invited him to perform at our Gururao Deshpande

All-Night Sangeet Samaroh. Our perseverance paid off. The festival, initially held in a house, drew an overwhelming response and the venue was overflowing with people. Pt. Kaikini was surprised and euphoric. He sang for over three hours and later told me that he would gladly take back his words. After that unforgettable night, I never looked back," says Pt. Torvi, recalling his pioneering initiative. 'Dharohar', conceptualised by the music organisation Sur Naman: Nada Rupa Saraswathi, paid a fitting tribute to Pt. Torvi by showcasing the family's distinguished musical lineage. The audience was treated to two engaging Hindustani vocal recitals: first by Rishabh Badseshi, Pt. Torvi's grandson, and then by the

maestro himself. The event marked a significant milestone for Sur Naman as it celebrated its 15th anniversary. For its president, Pt. Keerti Kumar Badseshi, the occasion was doubly special. The father and guru of the young debutant, Rishabh Badseshi, he was also honouring his own guru, Pt. Torvi, on the latter's 78th birthday and commemorating 70 years of his musical journey. Rishabh Badseshi handled his maiden concert with composure and confidence. A mechanical engineer by profession, as a child, whenever he heard his grandfather render Miyan Ki Todi, tears would well up in his eyes. So it wasn't surprising that Rishabh took to music. In his first public concert, Rishabh was

accompanied by two brilliant co-artists, Mihir Kalyanpur on the tabla and Surya Upadhya on the samvadini , both chartered accountants by profession. The proud grandfather Pt Torvi sat in the front row with B. V. Rajaram, member of the Central Sangeet Natak Academy, tabla exponent Pt. Ravindra Yawagal and samvadini virtuoso Pt. Vyasmurthy Katti. Rishabh presented the evening melody raag Bihag in an unhurried manner. He embellished the avartans of the traditional Vilambit Ektaal composition 'Kaise sukh sove' with meditative alaap and bol alaap, marked by exuberant taankari in the fast-paced Drut Teen taal composition 'Balam re more man ki ' and a lilting tarana composed by his father in the same raag. For the occasion, Rishab had aptly chosen a bandish 'Dhan dhan bhag mero shubh din ayo' in the night melody Rageshree, set to Teen taal. Mihir Kalyanpur's rhythmic support on the tabla was matched by the mellifluity of Surya Upadhya's samvadini. During the most anticipated segment of the evening, Pt. Vinayak Torvi took the stage for his concert. The piercing intensity of the raga Nayaki Kanada was captured in the luminous 'raagvistar' of the vilambit Ektaal composition, 'Banara mora pyara'. Ably supported by three of his disciples, Pt. Torvi presented a series of rare compositions in raag Nayaki Kanada. His voice traversed the three octaves with effortless ease, and remarkable clarity. The Drut Teen taal composition, 'Mope rang dar dar,' stood out for rhythmic improvisations centred on the *mukhda*, showcasing the maestro's consummate artistry. The concert was further energised by Pt. Ravindra Yavagal's *sangat* on the tabla and Vyasmurthy Katti's nuanced accompaniment on the samvadini. Known for his vast repertoire of Marathi abhangs, Pt. Torvi brought his recital to a close with Sant Tukaram's 'Deva mazha mi devacha' in raag Bhairavi. Suffused with devotion, the abhang brought the memorable evening of music to a deeply moving conclusion.

Shailaja Khanna

Entering Rita Ganguly's spacious, airy home in Kaladham, Noida, one is first struck by the lush greenery that surrounds it. The ambience speaks of a lifetime spent in the arts. Tamburas stand neatly stacked in a corner, while a wood-panelled performance space speaks of a long creative journey.

Recently conferred the Sangeet Natak Akademi (SNA) Fellowship, Rita Ganguly joins an elite group of artistes whose influence has resonated across generations. Yet accolades alone cannot define her. Singer, dancer, actor, director and author, she has moved effortlessly across disciplines. Equally remarkable are her wit and refined intellect. Her attention to detail is evident in everything she undertakes. At her music festival *Arohi*, for instance, she once insisted on a carefully coordinated colour theme and candlelit stage décor, creating an immersive experience that seamlessly blended the visual and the aural.

Born in 1940 in Lucknow, Rita Ganguly was drawn to the arts from a young age. She came to be known as 'Baby Rita' after an unexpected performance on the stage. Recalling the incident, the veteran says with a laugh, "I was quite young. Ustad Allaudin Khan and his disciples were on stage when the curtain got stuck, refusing to roll down. I too tried to do my bit, along with others, to extricate it. But I am told that amidst it all, I walked to the centre of the stage, did a namaskar, and started dancing. That, in a way, was my first public performance. I discovered I loved dancing and copied all the dancers I watched perform. Later, I trained in Kathakali at Santiniketan."

Her dance training was formidable – Kathakali under guru Kunchu Kurup and guru Chandu Panikkar, abhinaya from Pt. Shambhu Maharaj and Manipuri from guru Maisnam Amubi Singh.

Rita Ganguly speaks of her gurus with deep reverence. Her



Legacy Rita Ganguly shared a close bond with her guru, Begum Akhtar. PHOTO: RV MOORTHY

musical training brought her in contact with some of the greatest exponents of the 20th century: Begum Akhtar for ghazal, Siddheshwari Devi for thumri, Pt. Gopeshwar Bandopadhyay for dhrupad, and Kirana gharana vocalist Pt. Mani Prasad for khayal. She also learnt the Rajasthani *maand* from the legendary Allah Jilai Bai. A widely travelled performer, Rita Ganguly looks back on her years abroad with fondness. "I was fortunate to participate in many events overseas. I performed Kathakali, travelled with Yamini Krishnamurthy's Bharatanatyam productions, was a part of Birju Maharaj's Kathak presentations and also the Jhaveri Sisters' Manipuri performances. *Putana Moksha* was my most popular work. I travelled all over

the world with it," she recalls. It was during this period that she met her husband, Keshav Kothari. "He supported me in every way." She attributes her success to hard work and an unwavering pursuit of perfection. The diversity of Rita Ganguly's training is remarkable, but she sees no boundaries between artistic disciplines. "The arts are linked," she says. "You should not separate them. Without being a trained musician, you can't be a dancer. Without being a dancer, you cannot be a theatre artiste." Explaining why dance training is indispensable to the stage, she adds, "You have to be in total control of your body and its movements. Theatre is all about movement; you cannot falter on stage." Rita Ganguly's influence on

generations of theatre practitioners is profound. Associated with the National School of Drama since 1968, she remains actively engaged with the institution. Her most recent production, the 2025 Sanskrit play *Damayanti Nal Gatha*, based on a work attributed to sage Veda Vyasa, was an ambitious five-hour outdoor spectacle. Drawing on descriptions of classical Sanskrit theatre in the *Natyashastra*, she choreographed the production to recreate the grandeur and aesthetic world of an ancient theatrical tradition. "It was music that was my entry into theatre," she says.

Audiences also remember Rita Ganguly for her memorable rendition of the wedding song 'Dhinak dhinak dha' in the 2005 film *Parineeta*. She was 65 at the time. Dismissing the experience, she says, "Films are a waste of time for me. Without the live interaction, acting in films didn't appeal."

Rita Ganguly primarily identifies herself as a musician. "I have really worked hard on this; accepted almost all concerts that came my way."

Indeed, the major awards she has been honoured with have all been for her contribution in music; in 1999 the Sangeet Natak Akademi, the Padma Shri in 2003, and finally the SNA Fellowship in 2025.

A role model to many, Rita Ganguly talks about the artistes who have inspired her. "The dancer who moved me the most was Yamini Krishnamurthy. As a singer, right now I feel it is the young Dagar (Ustad Wasifuddin Dagar)... what voice control. Ravi Shankar was the finest musician, I feel. In theatre, Ebrahim Alkazi. And in the past, I loved the rendition of 'Nadiya kinare' by Badi Moti Bai."

The multifaceted artiste has also authored two books, and is particularly excited that her book on Begum Akhtar in English is set to be adapted into a film. Looking back on a life rich with artistic achievement across disciplines, she admits to just one regret. "I wish I could have produced more plays," she says. "Perhaps the *Mahabharata*."



Lights, camera, dance

Luru Screendance Festival aims to build a dialogue between dance and cinema

The first edition of the LURU Screendance Festival 2026 will be held from September 12 to 19 in Bengaluru. Presented by Vishwakiran Nambi Dance Company, in collaboration with Choreoscope Barcelona Dance Film Festival, the festival is conceived and curated by dancer-choreographer Vishwakiran Nambi. The aim, he says, is to explore "what happens when choreography begins to exist through cinema. When a body enters a film, it does not merely carry dance from the stage to the screen. The camera alters space, the edit reshapes time, and framing, sound, light and movement operate as parts of a single choreographic language."

The festival opens at Suchitra Cinema and Cultural Academy with the screening of 12 short films (four to 15 minutes) by independent dance-filmmakers from the U.S., Switzerland, Spain, Italy, Czechia to name a few. "While most films are on contemporary dance, we do have one film on Indian classical dance," says Vishwakiran, noting that "there

Lens view A still from the award-winning short dance film, *The Kitchen*, directed by Vishwakiran Nambi (below). PHOTOS COURTESY: RADHIKA G. & RAJIV SHYAMSUNDAR

is no particular theme this year as it is LURU's debut." The evening will also feature the inaugural LURU awards. This is a public event. From the second day, the festival moves online with *Present & Future of Screendance in India* at 5 p.m. IST, featuring a conversation with artistes and practitioners on the current landscape and future of the form. On September 15, 7 p.m., *Kalpna: Dance, Cinema & History* will revisit Uday Shankar's landmark film and its relationship to dance and cinema. On September 18, 7 p.m., the LURU artists' conversation will bring together selected filmmakers and award-winning artistes to discuss their films and approaches to screendance. These are open to all through RSVP (write to luru@vndc.in or WhatsApp 8095374522).

The inaugural edition received 108 submissions from 30 countries, bringing together films and artistes across diverse contexts, shares Vishwakiran. The concluding day, he says, is reserved for college screenings, community/school screenings, and the 'LURU x Choreoscope artists' gathering – this is a part of the festival's outreach and educational components, and is not open to the public. "Screendance has always occupied an interesting position between disciplines. It belongs to dance, but not entirely. It belongs to cinema, but not quite. LURU emerges from this tension, aiming to create a space in India where the form can be encountered on its own terms," says Vishwakiran.





Chitra Swaminathan
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Few films have woven themselves into India's cultural imagination as deeply as *Pakeezah*. While the film is celebrated for its haunting melodies and its poignant portrayal of the *mahaul* and *tehzeeb* of nawabi Lucknow, one scene remains etched in the collective memory of cinegoers. Salim, played by Raaj Kumar, enters a train compartment and chances upon Sahibjaan, portrayed by Meena Kumari, asleep on an upper berth. Struck by the beauty of her bare feet, he leaves behind a note that came to epitomise *mohabbat* for die-hard *aashiqs* of the era: “*Aapke paon dekhe, bahut haseen hain. Inhe zameen par mat utariyega, maile ho jayenge*” (I saw your beautiful feet. Do not let them touch the ground, lest they be soiled).

Of course, the English translation can scarcely capture the poetic charm of the original Urdu. For generations raised on a more measured, pre-digital expression of romance, these words came to symbolise a love rooted in gentleness and respect.

The film itself is said to have been conceived by director Kamal Amrohi as an ode to Meena Kumari's beauty and to the deep love they shared. Hence, he poured his heart and soul into the project. Though they were almost 16 years apart in age and Amrohi was already a father of

Pakeezah, once more

Meena Kumari's final film has been restored and will be screened at the Festival Lumière in Lyon, France

three, their mutual love of literature and cinema brought them together. They married on Valentine's Day in 1952. *Pakeezah* was often compared to Emperor Shah Jahan's creation of the Taj Mahal in memory of Mumtaz Mahal.

Thanks to the Mumbai-based Film Heritage Foundation (FHF), the classic can once again be experienced on the big screen. When it was released in 1972, *Pakeezah* was a box-office success. Now, in a meticulously restored 4K version, it is set to travel to international film festivals, beginning with its world premiere at the Festival Lumière in Lyon, France. It will also be screened at theatres in India. FHF spent nearly two years working with the Amrohi family to

restore the film, large portions of which had deteriorated over time.

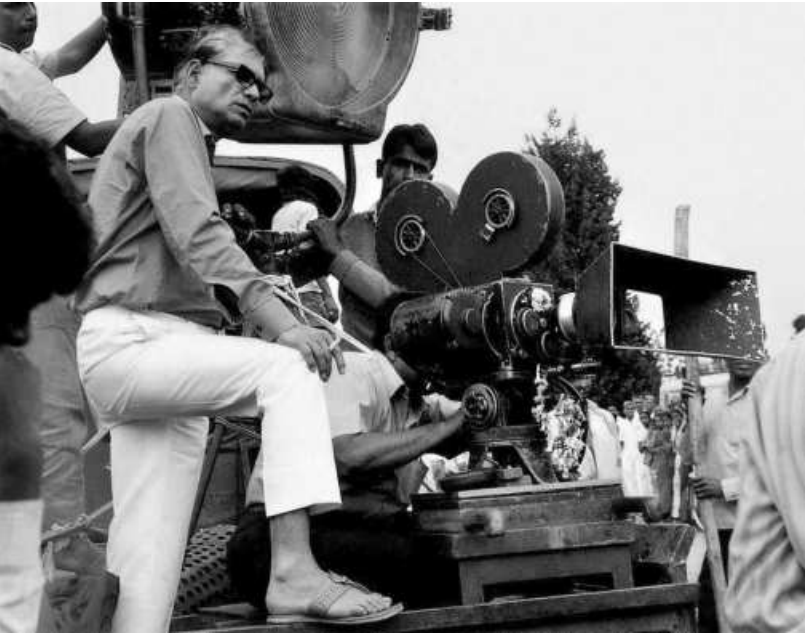
A member of the International Federation of Film Archives (FIAPF) since 2015, the Film Heritage Foundation (FHF) is a non-governmental organisation working in the field of film preservation. The Foundation has built a collection of around 700 films on celluloid and an extensive archive of film-related memorabilia such as cameras, projectors, posters, song booklets and books. Over the years, it has restored several classics of Indian cinema, including Shyam Benegal's *Manthan*, Girish Kasaravalli's *Ghatashraddha*, Satyajit Ray's *Aranyer Din Ratri*, Bimal Roy's *Do Bigha Zameen* and Ramesh Sippy's *Sholay*. Kamal Amrohi's

masterpiece will also be screened at the BFI London Film Festival, where it will be presented by FHF director Shivendra Singh Dungarpur alongside Kamal Amrohi's children, Tajdar and Rukhsaar, and his grandson, Bilal Amrohi.

Recalling the challenging restoration process, Shivendra Singh says, “I first watched *Pakeezah* as a child with my grandmother in a theatre in Dumraon, Bihar. Ever since I ventured into film restoration, it had been my dream to work on *Pakeezah*. I eventually approached the Amrohi family with a proposal and was delighted to receive their enthusiastic support.

“I knew it wasn't going to be an easy task. The original camera negative had almost melted, and the

Flashback Meena Kumari in the song ‘Chalte chalte yun hi koi’; and (below) director Kamal Amrohi on the set. PHOTOS COURTESY: FHF



other film elements were not in good condition either. I often wondered how I would restore Kamal Amrohi's original vision with the material available. Fortunately, we discovered original film stills, which proved invaluable. Equally important were Tajdar and Rukhsaar's memories of the time spent on the sets.”

Tajdar, who was at the grand premiere of *Pakeezah* in 1972 with his father and *choti ammi* (Meena Kumari), remembers the film cans arriving at Mumbai's famed Maratha Mandir in a palanquin. “Everything in our lives revolved around *Pakeezah*. My father had put in everything he had in the film and whenever we asked him for anything as children, his response would always be, ‘After *Pakeezah*’. This was his life's mission. I have so many memories of the film as I would regularly visit the sets on Floor No. 3 at Filmistan. *Pakeezah* has influenced generations of filmmakers and even today I am sometimes asked how did he achieve some of the shots.”

The filming of *Pakeezah*, which

remained in production for nearly 15 years, began in black and white in 1956. In 1958, the project shifted to Eastmancolor and was shot by the acclaimed German cinematographer Josef Wirsching. Frequent script revisions and the director's obsession with perfection continually pushed up the budget. Matters worsened when a fire on the sets destroyed several negatives.

The film faced numerous hurdles before it finally reached the screen. Kamal Amrohi and Meena Kumari parted ways, and the actress was later diagnosed with liver cirrhosis. At the behest of friends, she returned to complete the film. Wirsching's death meant that some of India's leading cinematographers had to step in, one after another, to maintain the visual aesthetic he had established. The production suffered another setback with the death of composer Ghulam Mohammed, who had created the film's celebrated songs, prompting Naushad to step in and compose the final background score. *Pakeezah* finally hit theaters on February 4, 1972, and Meena Kumari passed away on March 31, 1972, just weeks after the premiere.

An emotional Rukhsaar says, “As a 13-year-old, I saw the many sacrifices my father made to make his vision a reality. I felt that my father's legacy as a great master of cinema had been forgotten. I would like to thank Shivendra Singh for taking the initiative to restore *Pakeezah* with so much love and care. I cannot wait to see the restored film back on the big screen.”

Everything in our lives revolved around *Pakeezah*. My father had put in everything he had in the film and whenever we asked him for anything as children, his response would always be, ‘After *Pakeezah*’. This was his life's mission.

TAJDAR

Groundbreaking debut

Meet Apurva Arthur, the first woman student to perform mizhavu arangettam at Kerala Kalamandalam

Shilpa Nair Anand

Families and well-wishers gather outside the koothambalam on a cloudy morning on August 15 at Kerala Kalamandalam in Cheruthuruthi, near Thrissur. A quiet buzz of anticipation fills the air. It is one of the annual arangettam (on-stage debut) days at the 96-year-old institution, with mizhavu and Koodiyattam scheduled for the morning session. On this day, theatre practitioner Apurva Arthur makes history, becoming the first woman to have her mizhavu arangettam at Kalamandalam. A second-year post-graduate student in the mizhavu department, she is among the few women who have taken to learning the instrument.

The mizhavu is a large, copper, pot-shaped percussion instrument that accompanies Koodiyattam and Koothu forms such as Nangiarkoothu and Chakiarkoothu. The hide stretched across its narrow mouth serves as the percussion surface. Since the percussionist sits behind the performer, they cannot see the action on stage and must therefore have a deep understanding of the art form and its attaprakaram (text and abhinaya manual).

The mizhavu is not an easy instrument for a woman to pursue. From the performance posture to stepping into its wooden case known as the mizhavanna and perching on its edge, it's quite challenging. It makes one wonder what drew Apurva to it.

“Everybody asks me this. I



didn't take to the mizhavu, it found me,” says Apurva. She was around 18, when she first saw the instrument being played at Ranga Shankara in Bengaluru, where Adishakti Theatre Arts, Auroville, was performing their production, *Ganapati*. “It was love at first sight, rather, at first sound,” she says with a laugh.

She later joined Adishakti, where she began to learn to play the instrument and also to become an actor. “The first few years were spent in training (of the instrument). Then, Veenapani, the founder, told me that I could be a part of *Ganapati*, and it felt like I had climbed one of the biggest mountains. The other artistes were traditional performers who had already been practising and performing for over 20 years when I joined.”

Apurva's journey with the mizhavu began in 2011 at a 10-day workshop and chose to take the contemporary route. Her decision to study the

Upbeat Apurva Arthur on the mizhavu during a Koodiyattam performance. PHOTOS: THULASI KAKKAT AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

mizhavu at Kerala Kalamandalam “in the classical language” was to understand its roots and locate it within a cultural context. “The latter is important because I remember once, in Bengaluru, I was asked to play it softly to suit

the milieu. My determination to learn the instrument brought me to Irinjalakuda to train with Rajeevettan (Kalamandalam Rajeev).” While on a trip to Kalamandalam, she learnt that she could do her Master's in mizhavu. With Rajeev's go-ahead, she attended the interview.

Apurva began her journey as a student at Kalamandalam in August, 2025. But as someone who is into contemporary theatre, what does she intend to do after completing the course?

“My ideas are always going to be influenced by Veenapani. Her works, from *Ganapati* and *Brhannala to Bhima*, are deeply immersed in Koodiyattam, or draw from its ideas. During the creative process, her relationship with the mizhavu was almost co-dependent. She couldn't function without having the instrument around,” shares Apurva.

“For me too, the mizhavu became a kind of dramaturg. Many times, as an actor, I want to create a silent moment on stage, but then I'm playing the mizhavu in my head. It helps me connect the dots.”

Wittingly or unwittingly, she has created history, which she confesses was unintended. Arangettam is just the beginning for Apurva. “I intend to do shows, and hope people will start calling me slowly. There is a lot more learning for me.”

The fact that mizhavu is part of a ritualistic art form, and that she is a Dalit Christian practising it, makes her journey all the more interesting. “My father moved from Gulbarga to Bengaluru; his parents moved from a smaller town to Gulbarga. Ancestrally, we were leather workers. And I am now playing an instrument whose surface is made of leather. I often find myself wondering, ‘Who made this? My forefathers!’ It feels good,” says Apurva with a smile.



CALENDAR

Honour for musicologist

Ramananthan and Vaidyanathan, sons of Ramnad Krishnan, have organised a special event to honour musicologist Ritha Rajan with the ‘Ramnad Krishnan Award of Excellence’ on September 14, 5.45 p.m. at The Music Academy mini hall. This will be followed by Sunil Gargyan's vocal concert at 6.30 p.m. He will be accompanied by Bombay Madhavan on the violin, J. Vaidyanathan on the mridangam and Sivaramakrishnan on the kanjira.

Radha Kalyanam

Udumalaipettai Sri Nagaraja Bhagavata Bhajan Seva Mandali, Nanganallur, will conduct the 22nd namasankritanam festival on September 19 and 20 at SRK Mahal, Draupadi Amman temple street, Ullagaram. Radha Kalyanam will be performed on the second day by Udayalur Sri Lakshmi Narsimha Bhajan Mandali, while discourses by religious scholars will take place in the evenings.

In a new look

The Ashtabandhana mahakumbabishekam of Sri Adhikesava Perumal temple at Manapakkam village, Chingleput district, Panchamukha Anjaneyar vimana pradhishtai and the 13th year pavitrotsavam for the presiding deities at the temple will take place from September 13 to 16. Organised by Sri Adhikesava Perumal Kainkarya Sabha, special rituals including homams, pujas, tiruvaradhanam and teertavari will form part of the Pavitrottravam to conclude on September 16, 11.30 a.m. with satrumurai.

Aalaap presents ‘Quietly Dancing’

Aalaap's third edition of 'Quietly Dancing' will be presented on September 12, 3 p.m. at Narada Gana Sabha Mini Hall. The series celebrates artistes who nurture their practice across varied spaces and stages of life, drawing attention to the unseen journeys that shape their relationship with dance.

This edition will feature Bharatanatyam dancer Apoorva Jayaraman – a recipient of Ustad Bismillah Khan Yuva Puraskar. She is also a researcher, curator, writer and co-founder of the RootEd Foundation.



New play

Mugam Theatre group presents Uccham, a contemporary theatre production, on September 13, 3 p.m. and 7 p.m. at Medai - The Stage. Written and directed by Preethisha L, the play spanning 75 minutes, will explore identity, dignity, belonging, resilience and acceptance through the lived experiences of a transgender woman.